people."[5] Following this protest, and as the situation became increasingly more violent, Israel recalled its diplomats' families from Turkey. The Israeli Foreign Ministry stated that Turkish police had failed to provide adequate protection for Israel's Embassy and its consulate in Istanbul in a "blatant breach of diplomatic regulations."[6] Turkish authorities had taken sides in favor of the Palestinians without regard for Israeli diplomats security.

Operation Protective Edge was also unique in that, for the first time in its history, Turkey declared three days of national mourning for the Palestinians. Deputy Prime Minister Bülent Arınç told reporters in Ankara in televised comments as the Palestinian death toll topped 500: "We curse the merciless massacre committed by Israel against the Palestinian people, which has turned into a collective punishment. Our Cabinet has decided to declare three days of mourning [starting from July 22, 2014]."[7] There was some criticism of this decision because no mourning had been declared or even suggested when fifty-two Turks had been killed in Reyhanlı in Hatay by a Syrian bomb.[8]

Many AKP members denounced Israel for using extremely aggressive rhetoric. A few examples: the AK Party's member for Diyarbakır in the Grand National Assembly, Cuma İçten, posted on the podium a sign with Turkey's flag alongside the Palestinian flag with the words "Israel is Terrorist" while he was speaking.[9] On July 18, some AKP members left the parliament and protested against Israel in front of the Israeli embassy in Ankara. A Twitter tweet by Ali Şahin, who represented Gaziantep in the Grand National Assembly, noted that this was the first time in Turkish history that MPs shut down the parliament and protested in front of the Israeli embassy. AK's member for Çorum, Murat Yıldırım, said:

> for 15 days the occupying Israel has been carrying out terrorism, turning Palestinian soil into a lake of blood by bombing it. We are here now as parliament members; parliament has a day off, tomorrow will also be a day off.[10]

Şamil Tayyar, formerly a journalist for the *Star Gazetesi* and an AKP member of parliament, tweeted the following soon after the operation began on July 18: "May your race be extinct and may you never miss your Hitler [may you always have a Hitler]."[11] These words opened a Pandora's Box regarding antisemitic expressions in Turkey. On July 19, 2014 during the presidential campaign tour in Ordu, a city on the Black Sea, Erdoğan lashed out: "Those who condemn Hitler day and night have surpassed Hitler in barbarism."[12] Erdoğan's Twitter account declared the same, adding: "The terrorist state Israel struck and hit innocent children who were playing on the beach. With these barbarian acts, they have even surpassed Hitler."[13]

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